

Ethics of AI

Who Is Accountable? The Collapsed Bridge

CASE BRIEF

A newly constructed bridge collapses six months after opening, injuring several people.

An investigation reveals the following information:

- An engineer noticed a potential weakness in the bridge design but believed the risk was minor and did not pursue the issue further.
- The construction company substituted less expensive materials to reduce project costs.
- A site supervisor approved the material change without conducting a detailed review.
- Government inspectors conducted inspections but failed to identify the problem.
- Local politicians pressured the project team to complete construction before an upcoming election.
- Several citizens reported unusual cracks in the bridge weeks before the collapse, but no action was taken.

Assigning Accountability

Assume that accountability can be shared among multiple parties. For each stakeholder below, assign an accountability score between **1 and 10**, where:

- **1** = No accountability
- **10** = Completely accountable

Use your own judgment and reasoning. There is no correct answer.

Stakeholders

- Engineer
- Construction Company
- Site Supervisor
- Government Inspectors
- Local Politicians
- Citizens Who Reported Cracks

New Information Emerges

Following the bridge collapse, the government establishes a **Special Review Board** to inspect similar bridges in the region. During one of these inspections, the board discovers another bridge that was constructed by the same company using similar materials and design practices. The investigation identifies the exact same concerns that were later linked to the collapsed bridge. However, this second bridge has not collapsed because traffic volume has remained relatively low.

1. Who is accountable now?
2. Has accountability shifted compared to the original collapse?
3. Which stakeholders now have a responsibility to act?
4. Does knowledge of a potential risk create new responsibilities?
5. If officials decide not to close the bridge and it later collapses, who would be accountable?
6. Is failing to prevent foreseeable harm different from causing harm directly?